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Five years ago, Sonia Gandhi listened to her 'inner voice' and refused to accept the prime ministership of India, but by no means was that a renunciation of power. It turned out to be her first act in delegating duties. With the appointment of former finance minister Manmohan Singh as prime minister, what India had was a party leader who was more powerful than the head of government.

Manmohan acted as the Congress CEO in the enterprise called the UPA but Sonia always called the shots. In their five years in power, we featured the Sonia-Manmohan duo on the cover of INDIA TODAY four times, as their unmistakable, unchangeable power equation went through many trials and even survived a trust vote in Parliament over the Indo-US nuclear deal. For all the criticism, they kept their coalition flock together and served a full term. In the forthcoming election, the Congress is trying to cash in on this A-team again, presenting Sonia and Manmohan as a double-ticket. Manmohan is an economist and policy-maker, an acceptable and unthreatening prime minister. Sonia is the popular politician, working public rallies and talking about the needs of the *aam aadmi*, the plank on which the Congress came to power in 2004.

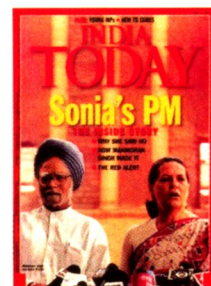
In the run-up to these elections, the announcement of Manmohan as the prime ministerial candidate even before the results are known is unprecedented for the Congress party. Even in the recent state elections, the Congress did not declare its chief ministerial candidates in advance and, in most cases, suffered for it. It is also a clear indicator that Mrs Gandhi believes her choice for prime minister made in 2004 was indeed the right one and she is therefore seeking a re-mandate for Manmohan.

The Manmohan-Gandhi team has shared campaign duties. The outgoing prime minister, recovering from heart surgery, has not campaigned himself but the powerful Gandhis have gone out to speak for him. Opposition claims of Manmohan being a 'weak' leader and a puppet prime minister have been countered in public by citing Manmohan's track record and achievements. As a prime ministerial candidate, Manmohan has been hard-sold as a man representing secure leadership.

This marketing pitch for Manmohan has another dimension and it comes in the form of a younger Gandhi, Rahul, who is now very clearly being groomed for the big job for the next election. A vote for Manmohan, the Congress wants the voters of 2009 to believe, is a vote for Rahul. For his part, Gandhi Jr, aided by his charismatic, telegenic elder sister, has divided into the thick of election campaigning, addressing more meetings than any party member.

Continuing our intensive election coverage of prime ministerial candidates, this week we look closely at the Congress and explore the dynamics of the Sonia-Manmohan team. Associate Editor Priya Sahgal, who covers the Congress for our magazine, spoke to leading functionaries, campaign managers and party workers to get a clear picture of where the Congress and its two-man A-team is going. The Congress's odd-couple tandem-team may share mutual faith, but over the next weeks, the voters in the world's largest democracy will have the final say on whether this is the kind of shared leadership they believe India needs.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR MAY
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